

Eleven projects, and the thing they all had in common

Nearly \$17 million went out for infrastructure and flood control. Knowing which pot your project fits is most of the work.

ONE DEAL

The Delta Regional Authority has invested nearly \$17 million across eleven projects for infrastructure and flood control needs.

Eleven projects. Not eleven programmes, eleven studies or eleven pilots. Infrastructure and flood control.

ONE LESSON

Most applications that fail did not lose. They were never eligible.

DRA runs more than one instrument and they fund different shapes of thing. The Community Infrastructure Fund is for basic public infrastructure, transportation infrastructure and flood control — water, wastewater, utilities, broadband delivery, roads, drainage. Things with a useful life measured in decades. The States' Economic Development Assistance Program and the workforce programme fund a different shape: planning, capacity, training, business development.

A community with a genuine need for after-school programming, applying to an infrastructure fund because that is the notice they saw, has not written a weak application. It has written the wrong one, and no amount of good writing fixes it.

The test is simple and it is worth applying before a single paragraph is drafted: **would this still be standing in twenty years?** Pipes, yes. A drainage improvement, yes. A three-year staff position, no — and that is not a criticism of the position, it is a statement about which door to knock on.

The second thing worth knowing: the region runs through Local Development Districts, and there are forty-five of them across eight states. DRA's own guidance tells applicants to contact theirs. That is not a formality.

ONE MOVE

Take your project and write one sentence describing what physically exists at the end of it. If the sentence contains a thing you could photograph in twenty years, you are looking at infrastructure money. If it contains a person, a programme or a plan, you are looking at a different fund.

Then call your development district and read them the sentence. They will tell you which door in about four minutes, and it costs nothing.

Source: Delta Regional Authority, award announcement and Community Infrastructure Fund programme pages, as published at 18 August 2026.

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